
Anthony Fauci's Senate hearing proves we're still living in 2020

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Six years ago, Match.com [released an ad](#) in which the devil met his true love: 2020. The couple spent their courtship sharing fun Covid-era activities, like stealing toilet paper, enjoying empty cinemas and stadiums, and taking selfies in front of dumpster fires, all to the tune of Taylor Swift's "Love Story." In a memorable tagline, Satan said, "I just don't want this year to end." Released in December, only weeks after the presidential election between [Donald Trump](#) and Joe Biden, it reflected the national mood perfectly: horror at what we'd all been through, and vast relief that it was almost over.

Sadly, it seems we are destined to live in that damned year until the end of our days.

The year ended on a high note. Biden was elected president, the new Covid-19 vaccines were about to become available and we felt we could look forward to a day in the not-so-distant future when going to the grocery store didn't come with a potential death sentence. Many people were back at work in one way or another, and the government had managed to get the American people through the crisis without suffering economic ruin. But it soon became clear Trump was unable to admit he had lost his reelection bid, and by January he and his army of surrogates and influencers had worked his MAGA followers into such a frenzy that they stormed the Capitol to stop certification of the election results.

At the same time, the MAGA faithful at home, which had, with the president's help, pushed snake oil cures and conspiracy theories about the virus for months, were unwilling to move on from their various obsessions. They were set to turn the anti-vaccine movement into a juggernaut that would be ready to take on the entire American public health system and challenge medical science in general. The "do-your-own-research" crowd had felt their power, and they liked it.

Still, most of the country eventually moved on. Things had changed in some ways. Working from home is now a regular feature of the work world, Zoom calls are an everyday thing, and digital learning and telehealth have become mainstream.

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Imagine my surprise, then, to awaken on Wednesday to a Senate hearing featuring Dr. Anthony Fauci in which he was being asked about hydroxychloroquine and Ivermectin. I had to check to make sure I wasn't accidentally watching a documentary about the pandemic. But no: Rand Paul, Kentucky's GOP senator had decided to scrape off the scab yet again by calling Fauci to face a grilling by Republicans on the Senate Homeland Security and Governmental Affairs Committee. Fauci looked the same. Paul looked the same. The daft conspiracy theories sounded the same. It was as if the last six years never happened. Déjà vu all over again.

Before leaving office, Biden [preemptively pardoned Fauci](#) — and for good reason. The doctor had become the whipping boy of the MAGA right, commonly accused of personally creating Covid-19 (in cahoots with Chinese communists, naturally) and then making a vaccine that they insist killed more people than the virus. It's all nonsense, of course. There are still debates about the origins of the virus, but the idea that Fauci created or enabled it in some way is ridiculous. The hearing, ostensibly called to get to the bottom of all this, is actually just the latest step in Rand Paul's petty vendetta

against Fauci that began when they sparred in a series of confrontations during the crisis.

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Despite being a doctor, Paul has always had, shall we say, an eccentric view of medical science, and he could never get the better of Fauci in their meetings. But the senator wanted the last word, and he got it. Ignoring Biden's pardon, Paul threatened Fauci with perjury if he "lied" during this latest hearing, a charge he claimed would not be covered by the pardon. In fact, the whole hearing was obviously a perjury trap.

Paul had released Fauci's 1,000-page [private pandemic diaries](#) — helpfully provided to him by Health and Human Services Secretary Robert F. Kennedy Jr. — which had been stored on government servers. The senator knew there would likely be inconsistencies between Fauci's memory and what he wrote at the time. Fauci's attorney wisely told him to assert his Fifth Amendment rights, which he did. Paul threw that attorney out of the hearing for attempting to explain why.

The senator's Republican colleagues piled on in their questioning of Fauci. Ohio's Bernie Moreno was especially grotesque, bellowing "[Who the f**k do you think you were?](#)" at the 85-year-old scientist. Even Trump was less harsh in his [commentary](#) about the hearing, merely saying that he stopped listening to Fauci after a while.

But the hearing wasn't the only recent time warp. Trump has spent the last six years attempting to rewrite the 2020 election, and apparently it's not enough that he made one of the greatest political comebacks in history. He needs to erase the fact that he ever lost in the first place, so he has deployed the intelligence community to find proof that he didn't. and decided to give a primetime presidential address on July 16 to reveal the findings.

To no one's surprise, it was [a dud](#). The information he presented was mostly old news, and he failed to provide any proof that domestic or foreign actors had any impact on the election that year — because they didn't. Even his MAGA media ecosystem was [left unimpressed](#).

But Trump remains undaunted. He's been willing to completely blow up the legislative session going into November's midterms unless he gets his way with the [SAVE America Act](#), legislation designed to suppress the vote, which Senate Republicans have so far refused to pass. (It will suppress their own voters too.)

For Trump and Republicans, the worst year in living memory will never end, and it's easy to see why. Like the devil in that famous ad, it's their idea of a good time.

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